

THE FACT DESK LESSON • LESSON 3 OF 6

Hallucination Hunters



A 45-minute AI fact-checking lesson. Students run the fact desk at the school paper — nothing gets printed until they clear it. They learn why AI can be confidently wrong, and the four-step method that catches it. Stands alone.

AT A GLANCE

TIME	MATERIALS	TECH NEEDED	PREP
45 min	The Fact Desk worksheet (3 pages, 1 per student) · Slides (optional) · board or chart paper for the RUN / FIX / KILL tally · pens or pencils	None — fully unplugged. Devices only add: desks can open the source they named and check the claims they marked C	Print worksheets. That's it.

OBJECTIVES — STUDENTS CAN...

- Explain why AI "hallucinates": it predicts likely words, so it can be confidently wrong. (*Exit #1*)
- Identify the checkable claims in a text (names, dates, numbers, places, quotes) and rank them by risk. (*drafts 1–3, C/S*)
- Lateral-read a claim — name a second, independent source that could confirm it — and give an evidence-based verdict: RUN, FIX, or KILL. (*second-source column + stamp*)

STANDARDS ALIGNMENT

CCSS ELA RI.6.8

ISTE 1.3.b

ISTE 1.3.d

Full text + taught/assessed map for each code in the Teacher Guide.

DIFFERENTIATION

- Support:** Drafts #1–2 only, with the hint "two false facts per draft (plus a shaky ending)."
- Extension:** Write a smooth four-sentence passage with ONE planted error; trade desks and hunt.
- ELL:** Label the claim TYPE (name, date, number, place, quote) above each underline; partners read aloud; desk words are glossed on p.1.
- No-device classrooms:** Built in — students name the source they would check. **With devices:** desks open that source and check the claims they marked C.

WARM-UP — THE STORY THAT ALMOST RAN (6 MIN)

Read this aloud, smooth and confident, like a news anchor. Then call the vote: **"This is going in tomorrow's paper. Print it?"**

"Our solar system has eight planets orbiting one star, the Sun. The closest planet to the Sun is Venus, which is also the hottest. Mars is called the Red Planet because rusty iron dust covers its surface. Saturn is famous for its rings — it is the only planet in our solar system that has them. Sunlight takes about eight minutes to reach Earth."

Expect most of the room to vote print. Reveal: **two sentences are false.** Mercury is closest to the Sun (Venus really is the hottest — the half-truth is what makes it slippery), and Saturn isn't alone: Jupiter, Uranus, and Neptune have faint rings too.

If the room votes HOLD: ask which sentence they doubt — most name Saturn and miss Venus. "One doubt is a start. The desk finds BOTH." *If a kid names Venus instantly:* "Write it down. We vote first, then we check." The second error usually slips past anyway.

Bridge (say it): "That sounded right because it was SMOOTH, not because it was TRUE. AI talks like that all the time — it predicts likely words; it doesn't check them. Today you're the fact desk: nothing gets printed until you clear it."

DIRECT INSTRUCTION — WHY AI SOUNDS SURE + THE METHOD (10 MIN)

Why it happens (3 min): "AI is autocomplete with confidence. It predicts the next likely word, like your phone guessing your next text. When the likely words aren't true, it says the wrong thing in the same sure voice. That's a *hallucination*." (If your class did the genie lesson: same trickster, new disguise.)

If someone asks "so is AI always wrong?": "No — it's right a lot. That's the danger: you can't tell by the tone."

The method (7 min): board the four steps; model 1–2 on the warm-up paragraph, then rank what you underlined.

1. **UNDERLINE** every checkable claim: names, dates, numbers, places, quotes.
2. **RANK** — you can't check everything. Would hurt if wrong → **C** (check). Common knowledge → **S** (safe).
3. **LATERAL-READ** — leave the passage; name a second, independent source that could confirm each C.
4. **VERDICT** — **RUN** (clean) · **FIX** (correct it, then print) · **KILL** (core claim fails — cut it). Does the ending still stand?

Say it plainly: "Don't ask the suspect if they're innocent — asking the same AI 'are you sure?' is not a check. LEAVE the answer, open a second, independent source. That's lateral reading."

If a student says "I'd just Google it": "Google shows you ten sources. Which one, and why? Name it — that's the log."

Hand-out (say it): "Pair up. Worksheets out — Deja's note is at the top of page 1. Draft #1 together, seven minutes."

ACTIVITY — THE FACT DESK (21 MIN)

Pairs are fact desks at *The Comet*, the school paper. Play the editor, not the answer key.

1. **Round 1 (7 min):** Both partners work Draft #1 (Priya's Moon column) together, each on their OWN sheet: underline, mark C or S, log their two riskiest claims, check a verdict box, write the note with evidence.

If a desk asks "is this one true?": "That's a checkable claim — where's your second source?"

Transition: "Round change: Partner A leads Theo's page 2, Partner B leads Marcus's page 3. Six minutes on your own sheet, then swap."

2. **Round 2 (10 min):** Partner A leads Draft #2 (Theo's quiz page), Partner B leads Draft #3 (Marcus's invention feature) — each on your own sheet. (6 min) Then: **"Swap sheets with your partner. You are now holding their draft. Read their log, add one claim they missed, and hand it back."** (2 min) Owners check their own stamp and write the note. (2 min)

If a desk finishes early: the Extension below. *If an odd number of students:* one desk of three — the third leads Draft #3 too; the swap goes round the trio.

Transition: "Pens down. Verdicts out loud — one stamp and your best evidence."

3. **Verdicts out loud (4 min):** Per draft, one desk per stamp given (RUN, FIX, or KILL) announces its verdict plus its best evidence — 5–6 desks speak in all. Then hands up, draft by draft: you count the room and write one tally row per draft on the board. No student walks to the board.

If two desks disagree on a stamp: "Score the evidence, not the stamp. Who named a claim, a fix, AND a second source?"

Transition: "Stamps are in. Now the part that matters after today: where else does this show up?"

DEBRIEF (4 MIN)

- Which planted error was hardest to catch — and what made it slippery?
- Where else does confident-but-wrong show up? Feeds, group chats, AI homework helpers...
- What's your personal "before I repeat it" rule from now on?

If nobody names the fake quote: "Did anyone check the Edison quote? Why not?" Quote marks feel like proof.

Transition (say it): "Bottom of page 3 — Last Check. Solo, four minutes. Two questions, then hand it in."

EXIT TICKET — LAST CHECK (4 MIN)

Worksheet p.3, solo: (1) how can AI sound 100% sure and still be wrong; (2) one checkable claim they saw online this week + a second source that is NOT where they first saw it. Collect; keys in the Teacher Guide.

If a student writes "Google it" for #2: "Google shows you ten sources. Which one, and why that one?"